Address to a Joint Session of Congress and the American People

President George W. Bush · September 20, 2001

Source: George W. Bush, Address to a Joint Session of Congress (Sept. 20, 2001), text via the George W. Bush White House archives. Public domain.

Nine days after the September 11, 2001 attacks, Bush addressed Congress and outlined what would become the War on Terror. He demanded that the Taliban turn over al Qaeda leaders, announced the creation of the Office of Homeland Security, and framed the conflict as a global struggle of 'freedom' versus 'fear.' The address is widely remembered for its high popular approval (Bush hit 90% approval) but also marks the start of a policy era that produced the USA PATRIOT Act, the war in Afghanistan (2001), the war in Iraq (2003), and the Guantanamo detention regime.

Connect: The PATRIOT Act (2001) expanded surveillance and detention powers. Compare with EO 9066 in WWII (Class 50). Are these justified emergency measures or repeated overreach?

Key Passages

Demand on the Taliban

> And tonight, the United States of America makes the following demands on the Taliban: Deliver to United States authorities all the leaders of al Qaeda who hide in your land. … Close immediately and permanently every terrorist training camp in Afghanistan, and hand over every terrorist, and every person in their support structure, to appropriate authorities.

'You are either with us'

> Americans should not expect one battle, but a lengthy campaign, unlike any other we have ever seen. … Every nation, in every region, now has a decision to make. Either you are with us, or you are with the terrorists. From this day forward, any nation that continues to harbor or support terrorism will be regarded by the United States as a hostile regime.

Homeland security

> Our nation has been put on notice: We are not immune from attack. We will take defensive measures against terrorism to protect Americans. … So tonight I announce the creation of a Cabinet-level position reporting directly to me — the Office of Homeland Security.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	Nine days after the September 11, 2001, terrorist attacks killed nearly 3,000 people, with the nation in shock and grief.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	Congress, the American public, the Taliban, and nations around the world.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	President George W. Bush, a Republican rallying the nation and defining the response; critics of the coming war and civil-liberties concerns are not heard.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. SAQ — civil liberties post-9/11: Identify ONE specific way Americans' civil liberties changed after 2001 and explain that change.
2. Compare the 'with us or against us' framing to earlier wartime presidential rhetoric.
3. Why did Bush focus on Afghanistan rather than Iraq in this 2001 speech?